fixture at Taunton. We fielded and by lunch the pain in my toe was bad enough to make me stay off the field for treatment. When we got to London before the first Test match at Lord's, I had a few scans done and it was revealed that the problem was again with the sesamoid bone. While there was some inflammation, luckily it wasn't serious enough to keep me off cricket and I played in all four Tests.

At Lord's on 21 July 2011 we started reasonably well after winning the toss, with Zaheer picking up Andrew Strauss early on, but we were thrown off-course when Zaheer pulled a hamstring soon after lunch. In such situations you can't do much but rue your luck. The loss of the leader of our attack undoubtedly affected us for the rest of the series.

I remember that on the very first day I saw Zaheer, way back at the start of his career, I told him he would always have to take care of his body and bowl right through the year to keep himself fit. His physique was such that he needed to do more than others to remain in good shape. Back in 2005 I encouraged him to play county cricket, and when he came back to India after playing his first season in England, there was no doubt he was a more mature performer. Over the years he turned himself into a match-winning premier fast bowler.

To add to our concerns, we lost Yuvraj in the second Test when he fractured his finger, then Bhajji suffered a stomach-muscle tear and Gautam Gambhir fell over and had severe concussion, which prevented him from opening the batting in the fourth Test. What's more, we didn't have Sehwag for the first two Tests, as he was still recovering from a shoulder operation. I don't want to take anything away from England, who played superb cricket throughout the series, but it was a remarkable sequence of disasters and it wasn't easy to cope with the loss of so many key players.

One unexpected complication at Lord's was that I found I had great difficulty picking up the ball from the new Media Centre End. England had tall fast bowlers in Chris Tremlett and Stuart Broad and I had serious trouble because the bowler's hand was sometimes lost against the dark-coloured steps above the sightscreen. This meant I had much less time to react than usual and I had to play the ball off the pitch rather than watching the bowler's wrist. From the Pavilion End I had no problem at all.

After the game I spoke about the problem with the late Christopher Martin-Jenkins, who was then President of the MCC, and he promised to